

Attachment Style and Dissolution of Romantic Relationships: Breaking Up Is Hard to Do, Or Is It?

Scott F. Madey* & Lori Jilek
Shippensburg University

**Scott F. Madey, Ph.D.; Department of Psychology; Shippensburg University; Shippensburg, Pennsylvania 17257. sfmade@ship.edu (e-mail).*

ABSTRACT - This study investigated the correlation between attachment and dissolution of romantic relationships in college students. More secure attachment was associated with less apprehension about seeing the ex-partner again, less blame assigned to the partner for breaking up, less likely to get back into the relationship, and readiness to start dating again. Secure attachment was associated to a modest degree with a more amicable breakup. An amicable breakup also correlated with less apprehension, greater willingness to get back together again, less blaming the ex-partner, greater willingness to remain friends, and readiness to start dating again. The implications of secure attachment for the successful dissolution of relationships and the importance of investigating attachment and relationship dissolution in a college population were discussed.

A considerable amount of research has been devoted to understanding the association between attachment and romantic relationships (e.g., Bartholomew & Horowitz, 1991; Gaines & Henderson, 2002; Hazan & Shaver, 1987). Secure attachment is associated with trust, stability, support, and satisfaction in a relationship (Pielage, Luteijn, & Arrindell, 2005; Simpson, 1990). Partners with secure attachment compared to those with insecure attachment show higher levels of verbal engagement, self-disclosure, and mutual discussion (Shi, 2003). Secure attachment is positively correlated with self-confidence (Feeney & Noller, 1990), commitment, intimacy, and passion (Madey & Rodgers, 2009).

Gaining more research attention is the role of attachment in the dissolution of relationships (Davis, Shaver, & Vernon, 2003; Sbarra & Emery, 2005). Strong emotions are expressed in relationship breakups (Sbarra & Ferrer, 2006), as well as possible depression (Bruce & Kim, 1992), dysfunctional behavior, such as stalking (Langhinrichsen-Rohling, Palarea, Cohen, & Rohling, 2000), and health problems (Kiecolt-Glaser & Newton, 2001). Davis et al. (2003) presented evidence that attachment-related anxiety was associated with more perseverations about the partner and loss of sense of identity. Interestingly, attachment-related anxiety was associated with both the desire to look for a new partner and the tendency to avoid new relationships. Attachment-related avoidance (i.e., detachment from one's partner and others and preference for greater interpersonal distance from the partner) was associated with greater self-blame, whereas anxiety was associated with the tendency to blame both self and the

partner. Others find that avoidance was related to less distress at breakup and that attachment-related ambivalence (e.g., lack of trust but also desire for greater interpersonal closeness) was related to more distress, with no statistically significant relationship found between secure attachment and distress (Feeney & Noller, 1992). Simpson (1990) found that although attachment predicts quality of the relationship while it is ongoing, no relationship was observed between attachment and post-dissolution distress. A longitudinal study found that those with an ambivalent attachment style were just as likely to be with the same partner four years later than those with a secure attachment style (Kirkpatrick & Hazan, 1994). Others (e.g., Le, Dove, Agnew, Korn, & Mutso, 2010) report very little association between attachment styles and relationship dissolution. Interestingly for some, however, the dissolution of a romantic relationship may elicit relief, possibly happiness, and a mutual respect between the partners. For example, having been friends before the relationship is related to still being friends post-relationship (Metts, Cupach, & Bejlovec, 1989). It is thus important to understand how attachment plays a role in the dissolution of a relationship.

It is also important to understand relationship dissolution while attending college as an interesting circumstance in its own right. College is a time of life that includes moving away from home, friends, family, and hometown. Attachment processes are important with regard to adjustment to college and may be observed with great clarity in this population (Pistole, 2003). For example, secure attachment correlates with exploration and comfort with college; whereas, preoccupation and fearfulness are associated with anxieties about academic performance (Aspelmeier & Kerns, 2003). College is a place where one faces new challenges and meets new people. Thus, attachment processes have important implications for how new relationships are formed and how old ones are maintained when one transitions to college. We, therefore, believe that it is important to focus attention on the process of relationship growth, maintenance, and dissolution within this population.

The purpose of this research is to investigate how attachment styles are related to thoughts about the partner post-breakup. We measured attachment style using the Relationship Scale Questionnaire (*RSQ*; Bartholomew & Horowitz, 1991). Siegert, Ward, and Hudson (1995) factor analyzed the *RSQ* and found that a two dimensional structure of attachment, secure-insecure and close-independent (i.e., the ease in which one can get emotionally close to others) may provide predictive utility in understanding the association between attachment and the dissolution of romantic relationships. This two-dimensional structure has been applied in the past to understand the link between attachment style and Sternberg's Triangular Theory of Love (Madey & Rodgers, 2009; Sternberg, 1988). In the current study, we investigate the relationship between the two-dimensional structure of attachment and thoughts about the partner post-breakup. We predict that secure attachment compared to insecure attachment is associated with less distress over the breakup, a more amicable breakup, less apprehension about seeing the ex-partner in the future, less blame of the partner for the breakup, and a greater readiness to start dating again. The relationship between close-independent attachment and post-breakup thoughts about the partner are harder to predict. Emotional attachment may lead to difficulty in breaking off the relationship or it can allow the person to dissolve the

relationship but still maintain contact with the ex-partner as a friend. On the other hand, little or no correlation may be found between independence and the ex-partner variables.

Method

Participants

Participants were 78 university undergraduates (females = 37, males = 41). The average age was 18.9 years ($SD = 1.08$). The sample consisted of 3% African American, 92% Caucasian, 1% Hispanic, 3% Asian American, and 1% Native American. Participants received course credit upon completion of the study.

Procedure

For selection into the study, participants had to have experienced a break up within six months of the time of recruitment. Participants filled out the Relationship Scales Questionnaire (RSQ; Bartholomew & Horowitz, 1991) and answered questions related to the dissolution of a most recent romantic relationship on a 1-6 point scale. A factor analysis by Siebert, et al. (1995) found that the RSQ can be reduced to two dimensions: secure-insecure (e.g., "I often worry that romantic partners don't really love me") and close-independent attachment (e.g., "I worry about others getting too close to me"). We conducted a reliability analysis of the two RSQ dimensions. Both the secure-insecure (9 items) and close-independent (18 items) scales exhibited high inter-item reliability (Cronbach's α s = .82 and .84, respectively). Thus, subsequent analyses using the RSQ were performed based on the two dimensions of attachment.

Satisfaction With the Relationship, Breakup Distress, and Amicable Measures. One item measuring satisfaction with the relationship was created: "How satisfied were you during the relationship?" Participants responded to this question on a scale of 1 (unsatisfied) to 6 (very satisfied). Distress over the breakup was measured using 4 items created by the researchers. Participants were asked to indicate how relieved they were after the breakup, how angry they were, how depressed they were after the breakup, how much stress did the breakup cause. Two amicable items measured how amicable was the breakup and if issues were resolved at the time of the breakup. Participants answered these questions on a scale of 1(not at all) to 6(very much).

Thoughts About the Partner. We also created five items to measure how participants relate to the partner post-breakup. We asked them to consider how apprehensive they feel about seeing their ex-partner, would they welcome the opportunity to get back into the relationship if the chance occurred, would they still consider their ex-partner as a friend, who do they blame the most for the breakup, and how ready were they to start dating other people after the breakup. Participants answered these questions on 1 to 6 point scales: 1(not at all) to 6(very much) and 1(yourself) to 6(ex-partner) for the blame question.

Results

Relationship Satisfaction and Thoughts About the Partner

The only gender difference observed was that women ($M = 2.68$, $SD = 1.89$) indicated they would be less likely than men ($M = 3.51$, $SD = 1.79$) to get back into the relationship if given the opportunity, $t(76) = 2.01$, $r = -.26$, $p < .05$. Gender did not correlate with any

attachment, distress, or amicable variable. There was no difference in gender and whether or not one was sexually active in the relationship ($\chi^2 = .99, p = .59$) or how satisfied one was in the relationship ($r = -.07$). Length of the relationship correlated only with sexual activity. Those longer in the relationship were more likely to be sexually active than those who were in the relationship for a shorter period of time ($r = .32, p < .01$). Those who indicated being sexually active in the relationship ($n = 52$) indicated they were more satisfied with the relationship ($M = 4.85, SD .78$) compared to those who were not sexually active in the relationship ($n = 25, M = 4.24, SD = 1.23; t(75) = 2.63, p < .01$).

Satisfaction While in the Relationship

Participants who indicated that the more they were satisfied with the relationship the less relieved ($r = -.45, p < .0001$), the more depressed ($r = .49, p < .0001$), and the more stressed ($r = .31, p < .001$) they were over the breakup. They also indicated they would be less likely to begin to start dating other people ($r = -.41, p < .0001$) and would get back into the relationship if given the opportunity ($r = .35, p < .01$). Although only approaching statistical significance, the more satisfied participants were with the relationship, the more likely they would still consider the ex-partner as a friend ($r = .22, p < .06$).

Reliability Analysis of the Distress and Amicable Items

A reliability analysis of the 4 distress and the 2 amicable items showed modest inter-item reliability (*Cronbach's Alpha* = .70). A factor analysis of the items using principle component analysis with varimax rotation revealed 2 identifiable factors that explained 65% of the variance (Table 1). Factor 1 can be interpreted as a distress dimension over the breakup. Factor 2 can be interpreted as the degree to which the breakup was amicable. The four distress items and the two amicable items were each averaged to create a composite distress variable and an amicable variable.

Table 1
Factor Analysis of the Breakup Distress and Amicable Measures

Item	Factor 1	Factor 2
How depressed were you after the breakup?	.87	.16
How relieved were you after the breakup?	.75	-.35
How much stress did the breakup cause?	.64	.52
How angry were you after the breakup?	.59	.42
How amicable (friendly, agreeable) was the breakup?	-.02	.87
Were issues resolved?	.14	.70

Note. Principal Component Analysis. Rotation Method: Varimax with Kaiser Normalization

Relationships Between Distress, Amicability of the Breakup and the Partner

The relationship between distress and the amicability of the breakup was correlated with the five partner items (*apprehensive about seeing the partner, willingness to get back into the relationship, still considered friends, who is at fault for the breakup, and readiness to start dating again* (see Table 2). Looking at Table 2, we found that the greater the experienced distress over the breakup correlated with a less amicable breakup. Participants who experienced greater distress in the breakup compared to those who

experienced less distress were more apprehensive about seeing their partner again, would welcome the opportunity to get back into the relationship, and were not ready to start dating other people. With regard to the amicable variable, participants who indicated a more amicable breakup indicated they were *less* apprehensive about seeing their ex-partner again, would welcome the opportunity to get back into the relationship, would still consider the ex-partner a friend, were more likely to blame themselves for the breakup, and were ready to start dating again.

Attachment Style and Breaking Up

We predicted that those with insecure attachment would find breaking up more distressful than those with a secure attachment style. As can be seen in Table 2, the secure-insecure dimension consistently correlated with reactions to the breakup. Those with more insecure attachment indicated more distress over the breakup, indicated that the breakup was less than amicable (although only marginally significant), were more apprehensive about seeing their ex-partner again (marginally significant), would welcome the opportunity to get back into the relationship, blamed their ex-partner for the breakup, and were not ready to start dating other people after the breakup compared to those with more secure attachment. No significant correlations were found between the close-independent dimension and the partner variables.

Table 2
Correlations among Attachment Style, Distress,
Amicability, and Thoughts about the Partner

	Close-Independent	Secure-Insecure	Satisfaction	Distress	Amicable
Close-Independent					
Secure-Insecure	.45**				
Satisfaction	-.01	.03			
Distress	.03	.32**	.47**		
Amicable	.06	-.19*	.07	-.26*	
1. Apprehensive about seeing your ex-partner?	.06	.20*	.04	.25*	-.38**
2. Back into the relationship if given the opportunity?	.11	.28*	.35*	.39**	.23*
3. Do you still consider ex-partner as friend?	-.22*	-.04	.22*	.04	.50**
4. Who do you feel is most to blame for the breakup?	.12	.24*	-.10	.18	-.29**
5. How ready are you to start dating other people?	-.10	-.23*	-.41**	-.58**	.25*

Note. + $p < .10$, ++ $p < .06$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$.

Mediation Analyses

Conditions necessary for analysis of mediators are observed significant correlations between independent variables, presumed mediators, and the dependent variable (Baron & Kenny, 1986). These conditions held for the secure-insecure attachment dimension, distress, and two dependent variables: willingness to get back into the relationship if given the opportunity and readiness to start dating other people (see Table 2). Two separate mediation analyses were conducted on each of the dependent variables to determine if the effect of secure-insecure attachment on these dependent variables was

mediated by distress. A bivariate linear regression yielded a significant positive relationship between secure-insecure attachment and willingness to get back into the relationship if given the opportunity (Model $R = .28$, $R^2 = .08$, $B = .71$, $SE = .27$, $\beta = .28$, $t(1,76) = 2.59$, $p = .01$). Secure-Insecure attachment likewise predicted distress (Model $R = .32$, $R^2 = .10$, $B = .51$, $SE = .17$, $\beta = .32$, $t(1,76) = 2.93$, $p = .004$). Distress significantly predicted willingness to get back into the relationship after controlling for secure-insecure attachment (Model $R = .43$, $R^2 = .18$, $B = .52$, $SE = .17$, $\beta = .33$, $t(1,76) = 3.02$, $p = .003$). Finally, to test that the effect of secure-insecure attachment on willingness to get back into the relationship is mediated by distress, a multiple linear regression with willingness to get back into the relationship as the criterion and secure-insecure attachment and distress as predictors showed that when controlling for distress, the effect of secure-insecure attachment on willingness to get back into the relationship became non-significant ($B = .45$, $SE = .28$, $\beta = .18$, $t(1,76) = 1.62$, $p = .11$). A Sobel Test (1982) found that distress carries the influence of secure-insecure attachment on willingness to get back together ($z = 1.97$, $p < .05$).

A mediation analysis on readiness to start dating again as the criterion and secure-insecure attachment and distress as predictors was also conducted. A bivariate linear regression yielded a significant positive relationship between secure-insecure attachment and readiness to start dating again (Model $R = .23$, $R^2 = .05$, $B = -.46$, $SE = .22$, $\beta = -.23$, $t(1,76) = 2.08$, $p = .04$). Secure-Insecure attachment likewise predicted distress (Model $R = .32$, $R^2 = .10$, $B = .51$, $SE = .17$, $\beta = .32$, $t(1,76) = 2.93$, $p = .004$). Distress significantly predicted readiness to start dating again after controlling for secure-insecure attachment (Model $R = .58$, $R^2 = .34$, $B = -.69$, $SE = .12$, $\beta = -.56$, $t(1,76) = 5.64$, $p < .001$). Finally, to test that the effect of secure-insecure attachment on readiness to start dating again is mediated by distress, a multiple linear regression with readiness to start dating as the criterion and secure-insecure attachment and distress as predictors showed that when controlling for distress, the effect of secure-insecure attachment on readiness to start dating again became non-significant ($B = -.10$, $SE = .20$, $\beta = -.05$, $t(1,76) = .533$, $p = .59$). A Sobel Test (1982) revealed that distress approached significance as a mediator of secure-insecure attachment on readiness to start dating again ($z = 1.95$, $p = .051$).

Discussion

Attachment style plays an important role in the successful resolution of a romantic breakup. It was found that secure attachment compared to insecure attachment is associated with less apprehension about seeing the ex-partner again, less blame to the partner, less likely to get back into the relationship, and readiness to start dating again. Those with more insecure attachment indicated greater distress from the breakup and that the breakup was less than amicable. Participants with insecure attachment welcomed the opportunity to get back into the relationship, but indicated that the ex-partner was more to blame for the breakup, and were less likely to be ready to start dating other people. Also found was that secure-insecure attachment was not a direct predictor of willingness to get back into the relationship and readiness to start dating again but was mediated by the level of distress felt over the breakup.

The study had some limitations. We created an ad hoc measure of distress and amicability. However, internal analysis showed that these measures were reliable.

Although our criterion to participate in the study was to have experienced a breakup within six months, we did not measure how long since the breakup at the time of the study. We did not measure whether or not the participants are now in another relationship.

Overall, these findings highlight an interesting dynamic in relationships. Those with secure attachment seem to be able to break off the relationship and maintain a respect for the ex-partner. On the other hand, those with insecure attachment indicated they would rekindle the relationship, but blamed the partner for the breakup. This ambivalence toward the partner may have implications for the dynamics of the relationship if the couple gets back together. For example, anxious individuals in a relationship engage in poor coping techniques such as withdrawal, wishful thinking, and self-defeating thoughts (Birnbau, Orr, Mikulincer, & Florian, 1997; Mikulincer, Florian, & Weller, 1993; Sprecher, Felmlee, Metts, Fehr, & Vanni, 1998). It might be the case that those with insecure attachment once back in the relationship may ruminate about who was at fault for the breakup with possible overtones for the quality of the relationship. Less secure partners may show hyper-vigilance of information that threatens the relationship or re-interpret innocuous information in relationship-threatening ways (Davis et al., 2003; Ickes, Dugosh, Simpson, & Wilson, 2003).

Although research has highlighted the negative effects of breaking up, a relationship does not necessarily end in animosity and loathing. Secure compared to insecure attachment was found to be associated with more successful relationship dissolution. Partners can come to a resolution of the relationship resulting in mutual respect and willingness to engage with the partner again, maybe not in a romantic way, but as a friend.

Attachment processes are important when understanding relationships in college (Pistole, 2003). For example, secure attachment correlates with exploration and comfort with college; whereas, preoccupation and fearfulness correlate with anxieties about academic performance (Aspelmeier & Kerns, 2003). Transitioning to college has implications for forming new relationships and for maintaining existing relationships. For example, those who have been in recent relationship breakups might still be in proximity to the ex-partners. Contact with ex-partners in venues such as classes, library, cafeteria, and organizations may re-kindle desire and love, refuel old hurts, or exaggerate the possibility of getting back together. Hyper-vigilance and misinterpretation of information when interacting with ex-partners may occur in these situations. Whether one is breaking up or making up the attachment process will remain an important component in romantic relationships.

References

- Aspelmeier, J. E., & Kerns, K. A. (2003). Love and school: Attachment/exploration dynamics in college. *Journal of Social and Personal Relationships*, 20, 5-30.
- Baron, R. M., & Kenny, D. A. (1986). A moderator-mediator variable distinction in social psychological research: Conceptual, strategic, and statistical considerations. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 51, 1173-1182.

- Bartholomew, K., & Horowitz, L. M. (1991). Attachment styles among young adults: A test of a four-category model. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 61, 226-244.
- Birnbaum, G. E., Orr, I., Mikulincer, M., & Florian, V. (1997). When marriage breaks up—Does attachment style contribute to coping and mental health. *Journal of Social and Personal Relationships*, 14, 643-654.
- Bruce, M. L., & Kim, K. M. (1992). Differences in the effects of divorce on major depression in men and women. *American Journal of Psychiatry*, 148, 914-917.
- Davis, D., Shaver, P. R., & Vernon, M. L. (2003). Physical, emotional, and behavioral reactions to breaking up: The roles of gender, age, emotional involvement and attachment style. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 29, 871-884.
- Feeney, J. A., & Noller, P. (1990). Attachment style as a predictor of adult romantic relationships. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 58, 281-291.
- Feeney, J. A., & Noller, P. (1992). Attachment style and romantic love: Relationship dissolution. *Australian Journal of Psychology*, 44, 69-74.
- Gaines, S. O., & Henderson, M. C. (2002). Impact of attachment style on responses to accommodative dilemmas among same-sex couples. *Personal Relationships*, 9, 89-93.
- Hazan, C., & Shaver, P. R. (1987). Romantic love conceptualized as an attachment process. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 52, 511-524.
- Ickes, W., Dugosh, J. W., Simpson, J. A., & Wilson, C. L. (2003). Suspicious minds: The motive to acquire relationship-threatening information. *Personal Relationships*, 10, 131-148.
- Kiecolt-Glaser, J. K., & Newton, T. L. (2001). Marriage and health: His and hers. *Psychological Bulletin*, 127, 472-503.
- Kirkpatrick, L. A. & Hazan, C. (1994). Attachment styles and close relationships: A four-year prospective study. *Personal Relationships*, 1, 123-142.
- Langhinrichsen-Rohling, J., Palarea, R. E., Cohen, J., & Rohling, M.L. (2000). Breaking up is hard to do: Unwanted pursuit behaviors following the dissolution of romantic relationships. *Violence and Victims*, 15, 73-90.
- Le, B., Dove, N. L., Agnew, C. R., Korn, M.S., & Mutso, A. A. (2010). Predicting nonmarital romantic relationship dissolution: A meta-analytic synthesis. *Personal Relationships*, 17, 377-390.
- Madey, S. F., & Rodgers, L. (2009). The effect of attachment and Sternberg's Triangular Theory of Love on relationship satisfaction. *Individual Differences Research*, 7, 76-84.
- Metts, S., Cupach, W. R., & Bejlovec, R. A. (1989). "I love you too much to ever start liking you": Redefining romantic relationships. *Journal of Social and Personal Relationships*, 6, 259-274.
- Mikulincer, M., Florian, V., & Weller, A. (1993). Attachment styles, coping strategies, and posttraumatic psychological distress: The impact of the Gulf War in Israel. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 54, 817-826.
- Pielage, S. B., Luteijn, F., & Arrindell, W. A. (2005). Adult attachment, intimacy, and psychological distress in a clinical and community sample. *Clinical Psychology & Psychotherapy*, 12, 455-464.

- Pistole, M. C. (2003). Linking work, love, individual, and family issues in counseling: An attachment theory perspective. In Erdman, P and Caffery, T (Eds.). *Attachment and family systems: Conceptual, empirical, and therapeutic relatedness*. Pp. 117-137. New York: Brunner Routledge.
- Sbarra, D. A. & Emery, R. E. (2005). The emotional sequelae of nonmarital relationship dissolution: Analysis of change and intraindividual variability over time. *Personal Relationships*, 12, 213-232.
- Sbarra, D. A. & Ferrer, E. (2006). The structure and process of emotional experience following nonmarital relationship dissolution: Dynamic factor analysis of love, anger, and sadness. *Emotion*, 6, 224-238.
- Shi, L. (2003). The association between adult attachment styles and conflict resolution in romantic relationships. *The American Journal of Family Therapy*, 31, 143-157.
- Siebert, R. J., Ward, T., & Hudson, S. (1995). The structure of romance: A factor-analytic examination of the Relationship Scales Questionnaire. *New Zealand Journal of Psychology*, 24, 13-20.
- Simpson, J. A. (1990). Influence of attachment styles on romantic relationships. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 59, 971-980.
- Sobel, M. E. (1982). Asymptotic confidence intervals for indirect effects in structural equations models. In S. Leinhardt (Ed.), *Sociological Methodology 1982* (pp. 290-312). San Francisco: Jossey-Bass.
- Sprecher, S. Felmlee, D., Metts, S., Fehr, B. & Vanni, D. (1998). Factors associated with distress following the breakup of a close relationship. *Journal of Social and Personal Relationships*, 15, 791-809.
- Sternberg, R. J. (1988). Triangulating love. In R. J. Sternberg, & M. Barnes (Eds.), *The psychology of love* (pp. 119-138). New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.